

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a magazine in Hong Kong:

Smartphones blamed as Hongkongers lose interest in the city's libraries

Hongkongers have been borrowing fewer books from public libraries over the past five years, from over 60 million books in 2012 to 55 million this year — with smartphones being blamed for the fall.

The city's education system was also criticised for not developing a love of reading among students. And one cultural commentator said many of the readers visiting libraries were there for the air conditioning or to kill time.

Jimmy Pang Chi-ming, head of publishing house Subculture, said the reading culture in Hong Kong had been bad for years. "Nowadays, Hong Kong people just surf the internet with their phones or tablets whenever they're free," Pang said. "Fewer people read books so there are also fewer new books being published. It's a vicious circle."

That seems to be borne out by the statistics, which showed that the most borrowed English-language adult non-fiction book last year was an old English exam question paper. It was borrowed 9,124 times.

In contrast, according to the department's statistics, the number of times the public libraries' seven e-book collections were used rose from about 142,000 in 2012 to 194,000 times last year.

Most borrowed books 2015	Number of times taken out
The Legend of the Condor (Chinese fiction)	11,094
HKDSE Reading Examination Question Papers (Adult English non-fiction)	9,124
The Five People You Meet In Heaven (English fiction)	1,849

Your group has been asked to provide suggestions on how modern libraries could be made more attractive to teenagers. You may want to talk about:

- what young people currently like about libraries
- reasons many young people don't use libraries
- new activities that might attract more people to use libraries
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. When was the first time you visited a library?
2. Who uses libraries more: adults or young people?
3. What types of books do you borrow from the library?
4. Why are libraries important?
5. How is your school library different from a public library?
6. Do we still need libraries now that we have the internet?
7. How do you think libraries will change in the future?
8. How would the closing of libraries affect the local community?